

1947", that this violence should be seen within the context of the political events leading up to Independence and the Partition, as two new countries tried to put in place the infrastructure that would help them make sense of the madness. No one community was at fault, each equally responsible for the sheer scale of violence that followed.

Cross-border transportation

Millions on the Move, a document issued by the Indian Government in 1949, indicated that about 673 refugee trains ran between 27 August and 6 November 1947, moving more than 23,00,000 refugees inside India and across the border. Provisions were made for evacuation from Hyderabad in Sindh via daily trains from Jodhpur. People stranded outside divided Punjab were taken in groups to railheads and then transported in trains. Between 1947 to 1948, 4 million refugees travelled across the borders in trains. They huddled wherever they could, crammed into compartments or on roofs, even holding on to engines, where possible. A photograph from that time depicts a man at the Ambala station charging 2 annas from refugees to use his bamboo ladder to climb on to a goods train.

Floods in the region towards the end of September disrupted train services until the 101st Railway Construction Company of Queen Victoria's Own Sappers and Miners from Bangalore arrived to repair the tracks, provide military escorts, and run the trains.

Trains of death

The country had been hacked into two on religious principles, and the moving population became easy targets for zealots and religious mobs. With the news of Partition filtering in, railway stations became open to attacks as hordes of people gathered at railway stations waiting to cross the new border.

Among the initial incidents reported was the 9 August derailment of a special train of Pakistani Government officials and their families because of a mine placed on railway tracks. The Lahore railway station became the centre of violence between 12 and 18 August as people desperate to escape the city gathered there. On 13 August, 43 workers were stabbed at the Mughalpura railway workshop. On 15 August, a train in Wazirabad,